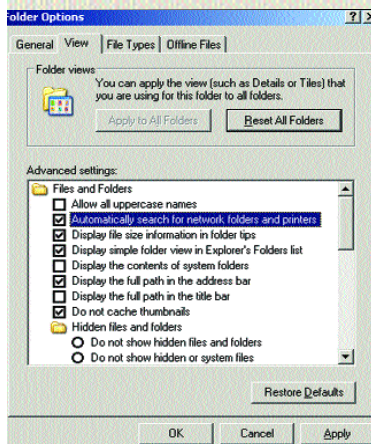




Setting the right folder options will let you work faster in Explorer

check 'Display file size information in folder tips' and 'Display simple folder view in Explorer's Folder list'. Under Offline Files, uncheck 'Enable Offline Files'.

Defragmentation

One cause of system slowdown is fragmented data. When writing to your drive, whatever space is available is filled, so even small files

can be distributed all over the place.

Windows may also split large files into many parts and spread them over the hard disk. This is fragmentation. To counter this, you need to defrag your hard disks once a month.

Go to Windows Explorer, right-click on a drive, select 'Properties' and in Tools, click 'Defragment Now...'. When Disk Defragmenter opens up, click Defragment. After the process is done, check your hard disks for errors. In the disk properties box, click 'Check Now...' under 'Error-checking'.

No compression and indexing

Drive compression and indexing is a feature of Windows XP that helps you save space and search your hard disk better—provided the drive is formatted in NTFS.

To begin with, if you have slower 5,400-rpm drives, or an older, slower computer, it's better that you leave these features turned off. The easiest way to check if this is enabled, is to double-click My Computer, right-click on an NTFS drive and select Properties. At the bottom of the dialog box that pops up, you'll see two check boxes called 'Compress drive to save disk space' and 'Allow Indexing Service to index this disk for fast file searching'.

If you don't search your hard disk for files frequently, you can safely uncheck the 'Allow Indexing Service to index this disk for fast file

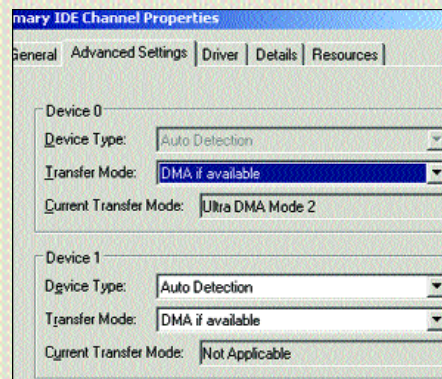
searching' option. Turning off disk compression, however, is a little more complicated. Not all users have 40 GB and 80 GB drives, and some would rather save every MB of disk space that they can, gladly waiting a few seconds longer for programs to load.

Another thing to remember is that if disk compression is already enabled, and your drive is almost full, turning it off can have unpleasant consequences—prepare to lose a little data. We suggest you turn off disk compression only if you have large hard disks, with space to spare.

If you change any settings, click OK and then make sure to check the 'Apply changes to <Drive>:\, subfolders and files'. You can do the same for all your NTFS drives.

Boost that drive

Go to System Properties ([Windows] + [Pause Break]), and then to **Hardware > Device manager**. Look for 'Disk Drives' and double-click on it. In 'Properties', check 'Optimise for performance' and 'Enable Write Caching on the disk'. Now, go to IDE ATA/ATAPI Controllers, and double-click 'Primary IDE Channel'. Under Advanced Settings, make sure 'DMA if



DMA access will let your drives communicate faster with other components

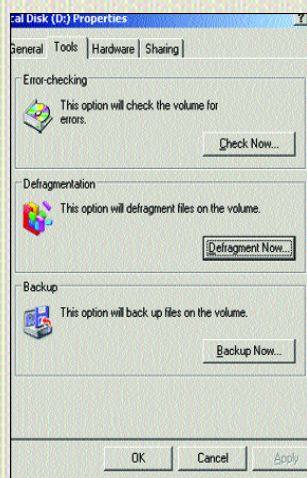
available' is enabled.

Do the same for the Secondary IDE Channel. You'll need to restart for the changes to take effect.

Unwanted fonts and applications

Not only do extra fonts slow down your system, they also increase bootup times. Use a font management tool such as Typograph (<http://www.neuber.com/typograph/>). Refer to the Quickstart article—'Fonts Sans Confusion'—in the January 2004 edition of Digit for tips to use Typograph.

The same applies to unwanted programs. Uninstall all that you don't need—too many applications slow the system down, even if you have space to spare. All installed programs have associated keys and values in the registry, and references to them are all over your hard disk. Try asking a hard disk that's sorting through 2,000 fonts and applications to hurry up!



Defragment disk drives once a month, for faster data access